

be the devil's followers. In the Middle Ages, many writers, who were also members of secret political or religious organizations, found an innovative way to communicate through codes. They published books which contained ciphers. This led to a trend of secret writing and every royal court across Europe competed to encrypt ciphers that couldn't be broken. During this period, many intellectuals chose to hide their scientific inventions and discoveries in secret code for the fear of being excommunicated by the Church. However, these mavericks trusted the future generations to unveil their discoveries, understand the implications and appreciate their efforts.



Masonic symbols

Early ciphers

The earliest and most commonly used cipher was the Atbash cipher, which emerged from Mesopotamia. Sharing many similarities with its Egyptian counterpart, cuneiform script was used to decode the message. Used in Babylon and Assyria, the Atbash cipher substitutes the last letter of each alphabet by the first, as seen below:

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
ZYXWVUTSRQPONMLKJIHGFEDCBA

The earliest cipher dealt with symbolism and is a key to an immense source of ancient wisdom, both scientific as well as philosophical. Early philosophers chose to subtly encode their message in verbose literature, intentionally meant to be heavy-worded. These ciphers were concealed artfully, either in a watermark, or through a repeated sequence appearing in a particular order. Under the guise of subtlety, many a carefully hidden message made its way to the recipient it was intended for.

Freemasons and their secrets

The highly controversial organization of Freemasons has brought to light the many uses of ciphers. While mostly misunderstood, Freemasons were essentially a group of highly intellectual individuals, chiefly believing in science. Their immense store of scientific knowledge was kept hidden through complex symbols and ciphers, sometimes even for years. Usually,